remained incapacitated following the Trump administration's efforts to block judicial appointments. This illustrates how major policy shifts can become difficult to reverse, even under more favorable political conditions (Howse and Langille 2023).

When confronting populist pressures, IOs must carefully consider the potential longevity of their policy responses. Short-term solutions may be preferable to measures that risk permanent institutional transformation. However, IOs may sometimes feel compelled to adopt less easily reversible measures. This could be due to a lack of viable alternatives or a calculated decision to prioritize long-term institutional resilience. For instance, building alliances with peer organizations may create "sticky" relationships that are difficult to disentangle but offer lasting benefits, such as bolstered resources or shared expertise. In some cases, IOs might conclude that the populist threat is not a transient phenomenon and implement permanent defenses designed to outlast populist administrations. These could include reforms that enhance procedural safeguards or diversify sources of support, ensuring the IO's stability even under prolonged challenges.

Ultimately, the choice between reversible adjustments and enduring reforms reflects a strategic trade off, one that balances immediate needs against long-term implications for the institution. By carefully considering the potential durability of their responses, IOs can position themselves to navigate populist pressures effectively while preserving their core missions and institutional integrity.

9.3.1 Legitimacy

IOs operate on the foundation of legitimacy—the belief that their authority is rightful and their processes and decisions are fair and effective. Such perceptions are critical for IOs to fulfill their mandates. Without legitimacy, states are less inclined to cooperate, skilled bureaucrats may hesitate to work for IOs, and donors may withhold essential funding (Hurd 1999; Tallberg, Backstrand, and Scholte 2018). Yet IOs' strategies to navigate populist challenges, particularly through appeasement and secrecy, can inadvertently erode legitimacy.

Appeasement, while sometimes necessary to keep populist-led states engaged, raises significant questions about fairness, which is tightly